VIKRAM RATHORE, 57
Jaipur

POLO AT THE PALACE

An ex-army officer finds new avenues to pursue his passions, polo and heritage resorts. It all comes together in a restored hillside fort palace and his own polo team

By ROHIT PARIHAR

In 2000, a few months after taking over as honorary secretary of the Rajasthan Polo Club in Jaipur, ex-army officer and polo player Vikram Singh Rathore helped organise the Polo World Cup qualifier in the city. The Indian polo team was the zonal champion that year. The years rolled on, but, in 2009, he had to quit the club to which he had dedicated his prime years. There was a battle for its control, in which Rathore found himself out of favour with the club patrons, the erstwhile royal family of Jaipur, making his exit inevitable. "In hindsight, it was a blessing in disguise. I looked back at my years with the army and thought, 'I'm still in my 40s, it's not too late to take a risk, set up own enterprise'," he says. Meanwhile, in 2011, he was appointed 'chef de mission' of the Indian polo team and helped it repeat the world cup zonal champion success story from the previous decade.

Often seen zooming around the city on his old two-wheeler, Rathore's hospitality business initially used to organise specially curated events for foreign tourist groups. Alongside, in 2012, he also started restoration work on a 14th century hillside fort and palace that his wife had inherited. Mundota thikana was a prominent *jagir* (estate) during emperor Akbar's time, entrusted with the defence of the Mughal kingdom's borders by his general and then Amber ruler, Raja Man Singh I. Rathore also set up a polo ground in Mundota, moving his half a dozen polo horses there.

> "AFTER EIGHT YEARS OF STRUGGLE, I HAD TWIN SUCCESSES IN 2017 WITH THE POLO TEAM AND HERITAGE HOTEL"
>
> VIKRAM SINGH RATHORE

In 2017, the Mundota Fort and Palace, situated some 40 km from Jaipur, was launched as a 38-room heritage hotel-cum-polo resort. Since then, additional accommodation has been added, and it is now a 163-room boutique resort which has become popular as a wedding destination and also as a location for OTT series such as *Made in Heaven* and *The Royals*.

Rathore had also been keeping busy following his other passion, polo. In 2014, he was appointed advisor to the Sahara Warriors polo team. In 2017, along with Parul Rai, the wife of a senior IAS officer, he bought the team, relaunching it as Team Achievers. It has since won the Indian Open Championship eight times in a row, besides many other major tournaments. Rathore has also mentored a number of top polo players, including Padmanabh, the royal scion of Jaipur and son of Diya Kumari, the current deputy chief minister of Rajasthan. Padmanabh also played for his team for six years.

In 2023, Rathore's success in Mundota was instrumental in getting 11 other polo enthusiasts to pool resources along with him to set up three more grounds in Mundota, under the aegis of the Patrons Polo Club. That has further expanded, and today Mundota thikana has five polo grounds and four riding and show jumping complexes. With about 400 horses, the village is now an equestrian hub for the sport's connoisseurs.

Rathore's journey has not been without risk. He's had to take huge loans to fund the Mundota renovation, and even sold off his house in Jaipur to fund daughter Divyakriti's training in dressage. But it's all been worth it. She won a gold medal at the 2022 Asian Games, and was the first female athlete to win the Arjuna Award for an equestrian sport in 2023. Next target for Rathore and daughter: the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. ■

Photograph by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR